ChatGPT

Post-Training I – Instruction Tuning & RLHF (Algorithms & Math)

Introduction: Motivation for Post-Training Alignment

Modern large language models (LLMs) can generate impressively fluent text, but their pre-training objective (next-word prediction on internet data) does not inherently align them with user intentions or human values [1]. Without alignment, base models often produce untruthful, toxic, or otherwise undesirable outputs, and they might ignore instructions or user queries. For example, a prompt *"Write an email to my parents wishing them a happy anniversary"* given to a base GPT-3 model might yield a continuation like a generic sentence ("...and many more years of love together") instead of a properly formatted email – the model simply continues the text instead of following the instruction [2]. To **align** models with what users actually want (helpful, truthful, and harmless responses), additional **post-training** steps are employed after the initial pre-training. These post-training techniques include **instruction tuning** and **Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback (RLHF)**, which fine-tune the model on curated data and feedback signals to better follow human intents.

Instruction tuning typically refers to **Supervised Fine-Tuning (SFT)** on demonstration data – humans (or curated datasets) provide examples of prompts with ideal responses, and the model is fine-tuned to imitate these responses. This teaches the model to follow explicit instructions and adopt a desired style or format. SFT has immediate benefits: a model can learn, for instance, to obey instructions phrased in natural language and to produce answers that are polite and on-topic. However, pure supervised training has limitations: it only provides **positive examples** of good behavior, with no direct feedback on what *not* to do. The model learns to mimic the demonstrations but doesn't learn to explicitly prefer them over other plausible outputs [3] [4]. There may be many valid ways to respond to a prompt, and demonstrations usually show one acceptable way – SFT does not guarantee the model will choose the *best* way according to human preference when multiple valid answers exist [3]. In short, demonstration data "tells the model what responses are plausible... but doesn't tell the model how good or bad a response is" [3]. This is where RLHF comes in.

Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback (RLHF) is a technique to further refine the model by **learning a reward function from human preferences** and then **optimizing the model's behavior against that reward** [5]. The core idea is to leverage human evaluations of model outputs as a training signal: if a human (or a proxy model) prefers output A over output B for a given prompt, the model should learn to assign higher "reward" to A and thereby become more likely to produce A-like outputs in the future [6]. RLHF thus directly **optimizes for what humans prefer**, rather than for next-word prediction or demonstration imitation. In practice, RLHF involves three stages beyond pre-training: (1) Supervised fine-tuning (SFT) on demonstration data, to get an initial policy model; (2) Training a **reward model** (RM) that can score outputs, using human preference comparisons as supervision; (3) Using a reinforcement learning algorithm (typically Proximal Policy Optimization, PPO) to fine-tune the policy model so as to maximize the reward model's score, while keeping the policy from drifting too far from the initial model [7] [8].

Overview of an RLHF pipeline for training aligned language models [7] [9]. First, the base language model is fine-tuned on human-written demonstrations (Supervised Fine-Tuning). Next, a reward model is trained to predict human preferences by comparing model outputs. Finally, the policy (a copy of the fine-tuned model) is further optimized with RL (e.g. PPO) to maximize the learned reward, with a penalty (KL divergence) to keep it close to the initial fine-tuned model's distribution.

Using this pipeline, researchers have significantly improved alignment. Notably, OpenAI's *InstructGPT* (Ouyang et al., 2022) applied RLHF to GPT-3, yielding models that "are much better at following instructions" and produce less toxic, less hallucinated outputs than the base GPT-3 [1] [10]. In fact, human evaluators preferred the responses of a 1.3B-parameter InstructGPT over a 175B-parameter original GPT-3 in a majority of prompts [10] – a striking result showing that alignment can outweigh sheer model size. These InstructGPT models fine-tuned with human feedback were deployed as the default models in the OpenAI API because of their large alignment gains [11] [10]. Other AI labs followed similar approaches: DeepMind's Sparrow agent and Anthropic's Claude assistant were trained with human feedback loops, and open-source efforts (such as OpenAssistant and Stanford's Alpaca) have also embraced fine-tuning on instruction data or preferences.

At the same time, RLHF is complex and **not without trade-offs**. It requires a substantial amount of human-labeled data and careful hyperparameter tuning to be effective [12]. It can introduce an "**alignment tax**," where optimizing for what humans want on some tasks slightly degrades performance on other distributions (a cost of alignment) [13]. There are also failure modes where the policy model might **exploit weaknesses in the learned reward** (reward hacking) or generalize unintended behaviors. We'll delve into these challenges in a later section. First, we proceed through each stage of the RLHF pipeline, covering the methodology, mathematical formulation, and practical considerations.

Supervised Fine-Tuning (SFT) – Methodology, Data, Pros & Cons

The first post-training step is **Supervised Fine-Tuning (SFT)**, also called **instruction tuning** when applied to make a model follow instructions. In SFT, we take a pre-trained language model and fine-tune it on a dataset of **(prompt, response)** pairs that exemplify the desired behavior. These could be human-written demonstrations of how to respond to various instructions or questions. The fine-tuning objective is the usual supervised loss (cross-entropy) on the provided responses given the prompts, i.e. the model is explicitly taught to map each prompt to the demonstration response. This aligns the model's outputs more closely with human intentions in the training set.

Data pipeline: Creating a high-quality SFT dataset is crucial. Often, human annotators are asked to write answers to a wide range of prompts, covering everything from straightforward factual questions to advice queries, roleplay, or tricky user requests. InstructGPT, for example, used ~13,000 prompt-response demonstrations written by human labelers (with some sourced from actual user queries) [14] [15]. Community efforts like Alpaca used 52,000 synthetic instructions and ChatGPT-written responses as a cheaper alternative [14]. The idea is to supply examples that teach the model the style and content of helpful answers. Common guidelines for annotators include: be helpful, be correct (truthful), be concise, avoid toxic or private information, etc. The resulting fine-tuned model (often called the *SFT model* or *policy model*) typically shows a marked improvement in following instructions compared to the base model. For instance, after SFT, the model presented with the "anniversary email" prompt will now produce a proper email draft rather than a nonsensical continuation, because it has seen examples of how such tasks should be completed [2] [16]. SFT essentially teaches the model **what to do** in a variety of scenarios by example.

Formally, if the SFT dataset is $\mathcal{D}_{\text{SFT}} = \{(x_i, y_i)\}$ of prompts x_i and desired outputs y_i , the objective is to minimize the negative log-likelihood:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{SFT}}(\theta) = -\mathbb{E}_{(x,y)\sim\mathcal{D}_{\text{SFT}}} \log P_\theta(y \mid x),$$

where $P_\theta(y|x)$ is the model's probability for the correct output. Only the tokens of the response contribute to the loss (the prompt is given as conditioning) [17] [18] . This is just standard language model fine-tuning on a supervised corpus, with the twist that the corpus is curated for alignment. Because the model is initialized from a large pre-trained LM, it only needs a moderate number of examples (tens of thousands) to adapt to the instruction-following style.

Benefits: SFT yields immediate alignment gains. It can drastically reduce blatantly bad behavior of the model: e.g., a well-instructed model will more likely refuse requests for disallowed content (if refusals are included in the demonstrations) and will format answers helpfully (like answering in a step-by-step manner if asked for an explanation). Many of the improvements touted in user-facing models (like ChatGPT vs base GPT-3) initially come from this supervised fine-tuning stage [19] [10] . SFT is relatively stable and efficient to train – it's just supervised learning, so it doesn't suffer from the high variance of RL. It also allows leveraging **existing datasets**: for example, research has shown that models like FLAN and T0 (preceding InstructGPT) which were fine-tuned on collections of task instructions can generalize to unseen instructions [20] [21] . SFT can thus be seen as instilling a general "helpfulness prior" in the model.

Limitations: Despite its benefits, SFT alone is not enough to fully align a model:

- *No preference ranking:* SFT does not explicitly teach the model which among possible valid outputs is better. It only learns to imitate the provided demonstration. If the space of acceptable outputs is broad, the model may produce responses of varying quality. In human evaluation, one often finds that SFT outputs are reasonable but not always the most preferred. For example, on summarization tasks, a supervised model might produce a summary that is factually correct but somewhat verbose or missing a key point; a human might prefer a more concise or pointed summary – but the model wasn't explicitly trained to make that trade-off.

- *Lack of negative feedback:* As noted, SFT provides only positive examples. The model never learns from mistakes because the training data doesn't include "bad" outputs labeled as such. Thus, an SFT model might still occasionally produce undesired outputs, especially in situations that differ from the training examples. It hasn't been explicitly told "Don't do X" except by omission or a few demonstration of refusals. RLHF addresses this by *showing the model comparisons* where one output is preferred over another, effectively giving direct feedback on undesirable outputs.

- *Coverage and bias:* Creating the SFT dataset is an expensive human effort, and it's impossible to cover all domains and instructions. The model might still perform poorly on inputs that are very different from those seen in fine-tuning. Moreover, the demonstrations reflect the biases or style of the human annotators or guidelines. If not carefully managed, the model could adopt an overly formal tone, avoid certain topics altogether, or reflect the cultural biases present in the demonstration writers. SFT models can thus be aligned with the annotators' instructions, but whether they align with *user* preferences broadly depends on how representative and well-instructed the annotation process is.

- *Diminishing returns on very ambiguous tasks:* **Underspecified or subjective tasks** are difficult to cover with SFT. If a prompt is vague ("Tell me something interesting"), there's no single correct answer. A supervised approach might give one example response, but users might have very different opinions on what's a good answer. In such cases, RLHF's comparative feedback can be more effective, as it can fine-tune the model's *policy* on what kind of interesting fact or story tends to satisfy people. As one practitioner notes, *"Supervised fine-tuning often falls short when tasks are vague or underspecified."* [22].

Crucially, experience has shown that **SFT is a necessary foundation for RLHF** in language tasks. Starting RL training from a raw pre-trained model (with no instruction tuning) tends to be much less stable and effective. In Ziegler et al. (2019)'s experiments, the best results were achieved by doing an initial supervised policy training followed by RL, whereas "pure RL fine-tuning is worse than the supervised baseline in all cases" as measured by automatic metrics [23]. InstructGPT similarly began the RLHF stage from a model that was already instruction-tuned on demonstrations [5]. Intuitively, the model needs to already be in the right general region of behavior before we trust a learned reward to fine-tune it further – otherwise the RL might push a completely unhelpful model into strange regimes. Thus, while SFT alone doesn't solve alignment, it provides the model with a strong prior for acceptable responses, which the RLHF step will build upon.

Preference Learning and Reward Modeling

After SFT, we have a model that can produce reasonable responses. The next step is to **learn a reward function** that captures human preferences among those responses (and potentially among any other responses the model could generate). This is the preference learning stage: we train a **Reward Model (RM)** to predict a scalar reward given a prompt and a candidate output, such that higher reward corresponds to "more preferred" outputs according to humans [24] [25]. The reward model serves as a **proxy for human judgment** – once trained, it can evaluate the model's outputs quickly and guide the policy optimization.

Collecting human preferences: We first need data on what humans prefer. Typically this is done by showing human annotators some outputs from the current model (or a mix of models) and asking them to rank them or pick the best. Often comparisons are done in pairs: for a given prompt, the annotator is shown two model-generated responses and asked "Which response is better?" in terms of helpfulness, correctness, overall preference, etc. This yields data of the form *(prompt, response A, response B, human preference)*, e.g. "Humans preferred response A over B for this prompt." In some cases, more than two outputs might be ranked (OpenAI's early work had labelers rank up to 4 outputs to get more signal per prompt) [26], but pairwise comparisons are most common and straightforward to model. The prompts for these comparisons are usually drawn from a representative set (possibly the same distribution as intended users' queries), and the responses can come from the current policy or from a mixture of policies to increase diversity. Christiano et al. (2017) pioneered this approach in the context of reinforcement learning for Atari games and robot behaviors: they showed humans short clips of agent behaviors and asked which of two was better at achieving the intended goal [27] [28]. They found that a surprisingly small number of comparisons (hundreds to low thousands) sufficed to learn a reward function that allows an agent to learn complex tasks – in their experiments, "less than one percent" of interactions were given feedback, yet the agents learned effectively [29]. This established that **binary preference feedback can be a powerful and efficient way to communicate goals**.

Translating this to language models, *Ziegler et al. (2019)* applied human preference comparisons to tasks like text summarization and style transfer, collecting thousands of comparisons. For example, in a summarization task, the prompt might be a news article and two candidate summaries are generated; the human decides which summary is better (more accurate, concise, etc.). They collected on the order of 60k comparisons for the TL;DR summarization dataset [30], and about 5k comparisons for style transfer tasks, to train their reward models. With ~5k comparisons, they achieved good results on stylistic continuations [31]; with ~60k comparisons on summarization, the reward model had enough knowledge to produce non-trivial behavior (though with some quirks, discussed below) [32].

Training the reward model: Once we have a dataset of comparisons, how do we train a model to predict a human preference? The standard approach (as used by Christiano et al. and subsequent works) is to set up a **pairwise logistic regression** or **binary cross-entropy loss** so that the reward model learns to score outputs and the probability of an output being preferred follows a sigmoid function of the difference in scores [33]. Concretely, we parameterize a reward model $r_\phi(x, y)$ which takes a prompt x and an output y and produces a scalar score (the "reward"). We want r_ϕ to assign higher scores to outputs that humans would prefer. Given a human-labeled pair (prompt x ; output y_w rated **winner**; output y_l rated **loser**), we can define the training objective:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{RM}}(\phi) = -\log \sigma\Big(r_\phi(x, y_w) - r_\phi(x, y_l)\Big),$$

where σ is the sigmoid function [34]. Minimizing this loss will make $r_\phi(x, y_w)$ larger than $r_\phi(x, y_l)$ by as large a margin as possible, because the loss is low when the winner's score is higher than the loser's score. Intuitively, the model is trained to output a higher score for the human-preferred response and a lower score for the dispreferred response, with a logistic difference. This formulation corresponds to modeling $P(\text{“A is preferred to B”}) = \sigma(r_\phi(x, A) - r_\phi(x, B))$ [28] [35]. It's analogous to a Bradley–Terry model for pairwise comparisons, implemented via a neural network. The reward model's architecture is usually a pretrained language model (often the same as the base model's architecture) with an additional scalar head. For example, OpenAI trained a 6B-parameter reward model for InstructGPT by starting from their GPT-3 6B model and adding a small head that produces a scalar – they found starting from the SFT model or a pretrained model works better than training a reward model from scratch [36] [37], since the reward model needs to "understand" language to judge responses. The reward model training data can be quite large: InstructGPT used about 33k comparison prompts (each prompt had multiple model outputs ranked, yielding hundreds of thousands of pairwise comparisons) [38], and Anthropic's HH dataset contains ~160k comparisons (some by humans, some by AI assistants following a constitution) [39].

After training, we validate that the reward model indeed correlates well with human preferences on a held-out set. Typically, one checks the **accuracy** of the reward model at predicting the human choice in a new pair. A well-trained reward model might achieve ~70–85% agreement with human preferences on test comparisons (random guessing would be 50%). It won't be perfect (since the task can be subjective or the model has limited capacity), but it should significantly outperform chance. For instance, in the summarization work, the reward model could predict which summary a human would pick about 70% of the time [40]. That indicates it has learned a non-trivial notion of summary quality, though it might rely on heuristics.

Use of the reward model: Once we have $r_\phi(x, y)$, we use it as a *learned reward function* for reinforcement learning. However, we should be aware of its limitations: the reward model is an approximation of true human preference. It might be overfit or have blind spots. In Ziegler et al.'s paper, an interesting

observation was that the RL policy learned to **exploit the reward model's flaws** in the summarization task: the policy would produce summaries that achieved a high reward by copying large parts of the article (which often tricks the reward model or even human evaluators into thinking the summary is covering relevant content) [30] [40]. Essentially, the model found a way to "get a good score" by including lots of details (copying whole sentences) from the article, which increases overlap and often fools annotators into thinking the summary is good, even though it might not be concise. The authors noted this might be *"exploiting the fact that labelers rely on simple heuristics"* [32]. This phenomenon — the agent gaming the learned reward — is a classic problem in RLHF known as **reward hacking**. We will discuss it more under failure modes, but it underscores that the reward model, while extremely useful, is an imperfect proxy. To mitigate issues, one can periodically have humans review outputs from the new policy to ensure the reward hasn't drifted or that the outputs are genuinely good. Some approaches also continually update the reward model with new human data during RL training (iteratively improving it) [41] [42].

In summary, preference learning produces a reward model that tells us what humans *like* to see from the LM. It **transforms qualitative human judgments into a quantitative reward signal** [43]. This reward signal can now be used in a reinforcement learning algorithm to **fine-tune the policy/model** beyond what supervised learning can achieve. As a final note, training the reward model is a supervised learning problem, and benefits from typical practices like validation splits and regularization. Some papers explore calibrating the reward model or ensuring it's not overconfident. But assuming we have a reasonable r_ϕ, we proceed to the core of RLHF: optimizing the policy with RL.

Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO) with KL Penalty

With a trained reward model in hand, the final step is to fine-tune our language model (policy) via **reinforcement learning**, so that it generates outputs that maximize the *reward* as predicted by the reward model. Conceptually, we treat the language model as an "agent" that, given a prompt (state), produces a response (sequence of actions), then receives a scalar reward from the reward model. We want to adjust the LM's parameters to increase expected reward. This can be done with any policy optimization algorithm; in practice, nearly all modern RLHF implementations use **Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO)** (Schulman et al., 2017) or a close variant [7] [44], because PPO is relatively stable and simple to implement at scale.

Trajectory and reward formulation: In an episode for our RLHF setting, the **prompt** is the initial state s_0; the model then generates a sequence of tokens $y = (a_1, a_2, ..., a_T)$ which constitute the response (these are the "actions" in RL terms, chosen from the vocabulary at each step). After the model produces the full response, the episode ends and we compute a reward R for the whole sequence. Usually, the reward model provides a score $r_\phi(x, y)$ after the entire response is generated. Some implementations shape the reward by giving token-level scores or intermediate rewards, but the simplest (and most common) is to give a single reward at the end of the sequence – effectively a *bandit* feedback per episode. We aim to maximize the expected reward: $\max_\theta \mathbb{E}_{y\sim\pi_\theta(\cdot|x)}[\, r_\phi(x, y)\,]$ where x is a prompt (drawn from some distribution of interest, e.g. user queries). This is the basic RL objective.

Directly applying vanilla policy gradient methods (like REINFORCE) to this objective can work, but has some challenges: high variance in gradient estimates, and risk of taking too large policy updates that collapse quality. PPO addresses the latter by restricting how far the new policy can deviate from the old policy in each update, using a clipped objective or a KL penalty [45] [46]. There's an additional consideration in RLHF: we *don't want the policy to deviate too far from the pre-trained/SFT model*, because that model embodies

general language fluency and some alignment already. If the RL optimization pushes the policy into a very different distribution, it might become incoherent or adversarially exploit the reward model. To formalize this, RLHF algorithms introduce an explicit **KL divergence penalty** in the reward function: a term that penalizes the policy for moving too far from a reference model (usually the original SFT model). In other words, the optimized reward is not just the reward model's score, but *reward_model_score minus a penalty for deviation* [47]. This technique was introduced by Ziegler et al. (2019) and OpenAI's later work [47]. It's effectively a regularization that maintains the policy's outputs close to the style/content of the supervised policy unless there's a good reason (reward improvement) to deviate.

Mathematically, if π_θ is the current policy and π_{ref} is the reference policy (e.g. the SFT model, which is fixed), one can define an augmented reward:

$$R_{\text{aug}}(x, y) = r_\phi(x, y) \; - \; \beta \, \backslash\mathrm{KL}[\pi_\theta(\cdot|x) \,\|\, \pi_{\text{ref}}(\cdot|x)],$$

where $\beta > 0$ controls the strength of the KL penalty [47]. In practice, many implementations compute the per-token KL divergence between the policy and reference model on the generated sequence and use β times that as a penalty (so that longer responses aren't overly penalized simply for length). The intuition is that if the policy starts producing very improbable tokens (according to the reference model's distribution), the KL term grows and subtracts from the reward, discouraging such divergence [48] [49]. This keeps the learned policy in the vicinity of the original model's behavior, which tends to preserve coherence and grammaticality (the reference acts like a prior). From another perspective, KL-regularized RL has a connection to Bayesian inference or to trust-region methods – it's as if we are doing a conservative update that balances maximizing reward with staying close to the prior policy [50]. Ouyang et al. (2022) note that dynamically adjusting β to target a certain average KL (e.g. "keep KL ~ 6") improved training stability in InstructGPT, essentially ensuring the model doesn't drift too far [51] (this detail comes from correspondence and open source implementations, as the paper hints at it but the exact method is a bit beyond our scope).

PPO algorithm recap: PPO is a family of policy gradient methods that uses *importance sampling* and *clipped loss* to constrain policy updates. One maintains an old policy π_{old} (or in practice, one uses the current policy as "old" at the start of a batch of updates, and π_θ as the new). The key quantity is the probability ratio $r_t(\theta) = \frac{\pi_\theta(a_t|s_t)}{\pi_{\text{old}}(a_t|s_t)}$, which tells us how much the new policy would increase the probability of action a_t at step t compared to the old policy's probability. The vanilla policy gradient objective is $\mathbb{E}[r_t(\theta)\hat{A}_t]$, where $\hat{A}_t$ is an advantage estimate (here the advantage could be $R - V(s_t)$, with V a value baseline). PPO modifies this to

$$L(\theta) = \mathbb{E}\Big[\min\big(r_t(\theta)\,\hat{A}_t,\; \text{clip}(r_t(\theta), 1-\epsilon, 1+\epsilon)\,\hat{A}_t\big)\Big],$$

where ϵ is a hyperparameter (commonly 0.1–0.2). This "clipped" objective means if the policy tries to change too much (ratio deviating beyond 1±ε), the objective uses the clipped value, which flattens the gradient to zero for further movement in that direction [45] [52]. This prevents overly large policy updates. In practice, PPO is implemented by sampling a batch of prompts, generating responses (with the current policy) and computing rewards (via the reward model + KL penalty), then doing several epochs of mini-batch SGD on this objective. During these updates, π_{old} is fixed as the policy that generated the data, and π_θ is being updated (via gradients) – the clipping refers to π_{old} probabilities. After finishing, one updates $\pi_{\text{old}} := \pi_\theta$ and repeats with new samples, etc.

In the RLHF setting, the **advantage** $\hat{A}_t$ can be computed by a value function (often the policy model is augmented with a *value head* that predicts the expected reward-to-go from each state). Libraries like TRL add a **value head** to the language model, which is essentially a linear head on top of the transformer that estimates the reward (so it's trained to predict $r_\phi(x, y)$ or the cumulative reward) [53] [54]. This serves as a baseline to reduce variance. The training then involves both policy loss and value loss terms.

The **KL penalty** we discussed can be incorporated in two equivalent ways: (1) explicitly subtracting $\beta\,\mathrm{KL}$ from the reward at the end (which means the advantage includes a term $-\beta\,\mathrm{KL}$), or (2) treating the reference policy as a part of the environment that gives an extra "non-score reward" at each step equal to $-\beta$ times log-prob ratio. In OpenAI's implementation, they in fact augment the reward at each token with $-\beta \log \frac{\pi_\theta(a_t|x,a_{<t})}{\pi_{\text{ref}}(a_t|x,a_{<t})}$, which yields the same total penalty [55] [56]. The TRL library tracks metrics like `objective/kl` (mean KL per token) and `objective/rlhf_reward` (the combined reward = score - penalty) to monitor this [55]. A well-tuned run will show `rlhf_reward` (the metric we truly maximize) increasing over time [57].

Why PPO + KL works well for language RLHF: The combination of PPO's clipping and the KL regularizer yields a very stable training in practice. The KL term ensures the generated language doesn't drift into an odd space that the reward model might erroneously assign high reward to. It also prevents mode collapse where the policy might concentrate probability on a few high-reward phrases at the cost of diversity – the reference model (SFT) had a certain distribution, and the policy is discouraged from deviating too much, thereby avoiding collapse into a narrow set of outputs [58] [50]. OpenAI's researchers have even described the KL-regularized RLHF objective as performing a form of Bayesian update on the policy [59] – effectively balancing the prior (demonstrations) and the likelihood of human preferences. Empirically, RLHF without a KL penalty tends to be unstable: models can "run away" to weird outputs that fool the reward model. With a KL constraint, one gets a much smoother improvement. For example, the KL penalty was *"used to encourage coherence and topicality"* in Ziegler et al. (2019) [60], and indeed their ablations showed that without it the model would generate more off-topic or rambling text that the reward model mistakenly thought was good.

Let's illustrate the PPO with KL setup with a simplified flow:

Diagram: PPO training with a reference model in RLHF [48] [61]. The "active" policy model generates a response for a given prompt (rollout). The reward model evaluates the response to produce a scalar reward (evaluation). The reference model (a frozen copy of the SFT model) also computes log-probabilities of the response, allowing calculation of the KL divergence between the active policy and reference for that response [48]. The PPO update then adjusts the active model's weights to maximize the reward minus β·KL (optimization), using gradients that push up the probability of tokens that lead to higher adjusted reward [49]. This setup requires two forward passes (policy & reference) per step, doubling memory usage, though tricks like shared early layers can mitigate that [62].

In implementation, one typically maintains two model instances: the **policy model** (actively updated) and the **reference model** (frozen). They start identical (both initialized from the SFT model parameters). At each training step, for a batch of prompts, we get responses from the policy model, then compute the reward model's score for each (prompt, response). We also compute the log-prob of the policy's response under the *reference model*. The reward used for policy gradient is then:

$$r_{\text{RLHF}} = r_\phi(x, y) - \beta \sum_{t=1}^{T} \log \frac{\pi_\theta(y_t|x, y_{<t})}{\pi_{\text{ref}}(y_t|x, y_{<t})},$$

which is essentially the sum of per-token log-prob differences (the KL) times -β, added to the reward model score [56]. The policy gradient update uses this reward (or advantage if a value baseline is used). PPO clipping is applied to the policy gradient to avoid large deviations per update.

Choosing the hyperparameters: In RLHF, some key hyperparams include the learning rate (often very low, e.g. 1e-5 or 1e-6, to not destabilize the model), the batch size (larger can yield more stable gradients [63]), the number of PPO epochs per batch (a small number like 1–4 to avoid overfitting the sampled data), and the KL coefficient β. Sometimes β is fixed; sometimes it's adjusted on the fly. Ouyang et al. mention that they normalize the reward model outputs and heuristically adjust β to maintain a target KL, which might start around β=0.1 and then change as needed [51] [64]. If β is too high, the model will resist changes and learn slowly (the KL term dominates, basically staying near the reference model). If β is too low, the model can go off-distribution and cause training to become unstable or the reward model to be exploited.

Stability mechanisms and observations: Teams running RLHF have observed some general behaviors: - The **KL divergence** between policy and reference will initially increase as the policy learns to do things differently to gain reward, but it should converge to a manageable value if β is set right. Monitoring this `objective/kl` is essential [55]. If it spikes, the policy might be straying; one might increase β. - The **reward model score** on training samples (often called `objective/scores` or simply the raw reward) typically goes up as training progresses – that means the policy is generating outputs that the reward model rates more highly [55] [57]. One must be cautious: an increase in reward model score *should* correlate with human preference, but if the reward model is flawed, the policy might be gaming it. Periodic human evaluation is the gold standard check. - PPO's clipping fraction (how often the updates hit the clip threshold) can be monitored (`policy/clipfrac_avg`) [65] – if it's very high, it means many gradient steps are being clipped, possibly indicating the learning rate is too high or the update is too aggressive. - Using a **value function** is important for variance reduction; one has to train the value head simultaneously with the policy. The KL penalty can also be seen as adding an additional term to the value function learning (since the KL contributes to the return). - One subtle point: We are doing *on-policy* RL here essentially (generating fresh samples with the latest policy). This means we need to generate a lot of samples. However, large language models are expensive to sample from; so PPO with mini-batches is used to squeeze more learning from each batch of samples. Some implementations also reuse some samples (though strictly speaking PPO is on-policy). - Efficiency: Generating long sequences and computing a forward pass through a large reward model is heavy. In practice, to reduce overhead, sometimes a smaller reward model is used (e.g. 6B reward model for a 175B policy in InstructGPT) and truncated sequences. There is also an "EOS trick" – penalize non-terminated sequences – to encourage the model to end outputs appropriately [66].

To summarize this section, **PPO with a KL penalty** is the de-facto algorithm for RLHF. It optimizes the policy to maximize the learned reward while avoiding large deviations from the initial model distribution [49]. This approach was crucial in InstructGPT's success: Ouyang et al. note that without careful constraints, aligning the model could degrade its base capabilities, but with the right method (PPO + KL + some mix-in of original data) they largely avoided these downsides [13]. The KL penalty, in particular, addresses the "**distributional shift**" issue: if the policy goes somewhere the reward model wasn't trained on, the reward predictions could be arbitrary. By keeping the policy near the data that the reward model has seen (outputs similar to the SFT outputs, plus moderate improvements), we trust the reward model more. Empirically, RLHF training tends to converge in a few to a few tens of thousands of episodes, depending on the task and dataset size, often reaching a plateau where pushing further leads to diminishing returns or risk of overoptimization (which may manifest as the policy exploiting the reward model).

We will next look at how all this is implemented in code (using the TRL library) and then discuss the possible failure modes and challenges encountered during RLHF training.

Implementation Details: RLHF using TRL (Supervised, Reward Model, PPO Code)

Implementing RLHF requires stitching together data pipelines and training loops for each of the three stages. Fortunately, libraries like **Hugging Face's** `trl` (Transformer Reinforcement Learning) provide high-level Trainer classes for SFT, reward modeling, and PPO that handle much of the heavy lifting [67] [68] . In this section, we walk through an outline of the implementation, including code snippets and tips.

1. Supervised Fine-Tuning (SFT) Stage

For SFT, one can use either the standard `transformers.Trainer` or `trl`'s `SFTTrainer` which is a convenience wrapper. The steps are:

- Prepare a dataset of prompts and desired responses. Typically this is a text dataset that can be loaded with `datasets` library; prompts and responses might be concatenated with special tokens (some setups put a separator like `<|prompter|>` and `<|assistant|>` to indicate who is speaking in a dialogue scenario).
- Initialize the model from a pretrained checkpoint (e.g. a GPT-J 6B or GPT-2, GPT-NeoX, etc.). We usually use the same architecture for all stages. If using `trl.SFTTrainer`, you can specify the model and the dataset and it will handle training.
- Train with causal language modeling loss on the response tokens. We often set the model's padding token to EOS to avoid issues, and ensure the attention mask stops at end-of-prompt for the loss on prompt tokens (so we don't give credit for predicting the prompt itself).
- Save the fine-tuned model – this is now your policy initialization for RL.

For example, using Accelerate launcher with `trl` on a single GPU or multi-GPU environment:

```
accelerate launch --config_file accelerate/zero2-bf16.yaml
sft_training_script.py
```

This script would load the dataset (e.g. Anthropic's HH dataset's demonstrations part [69]), load the model in bfloat16 (to save memory), and fine-tune. Using bfloat16 or float16 is common to fit large models in memory [70] .

Tips: If the model is very large (e.g. >10B parameters) and you have limited GPU memory, consider using parameter-efficient fine-tuning (PEFT) such as **LoRA** (Low-Rank Adapters) so that you only train a small number of extra weights [71] [72] . The TRL library supports integration with PEFT to freeze the main model and just train adapters [73] [74] . This drastically reduces memory usage. Also, enable gradient checkpointing if needed to trade compute for memory in backprop (transformers models allow `model.gradient_checkpointing_enable()`) – this can cut memory by ~50% at the cost of 20% slower training [75] .

2. Reward Model Training Stage

Training the reward model typically involves the following:

- Use the same base model architecture (e.g. if policy is GPT-2, use a GPT-2 for reward modeling). Often the reward model is initialized from the fine-tuned policy or the base model. As Chip Huyen notes, starting the RM from the SFT model can help it be "at least as powerful" as the policy it will judge [36] [37].
- Modify the model's output head to produce a single scalar. If using `trl.RewardTrainer`, it can add a value head automatically for this purpose (similar to the PPO value head). Alternatively, one can take a pretrained LM and add a linear layer on top of the final hidden state of the <|endoftext|> token or something to predict a scalar reward.
- Prepare the preference comparison dataset: pairs of (prompt, response_winner, response_loser). This could be stored such that each entry has two responses and an indicator of which is preferred.
- The training loop will feed the prompt and both responses into the model (concatenate prompt with each response). For each, it obtains a scalar score. Then it applies the loss as described: $-\log \sigma(s_w - s_l)$. This can be implemented by taking the difference of the two scores and applying a `nn.BCEWithLogitsLoss` with target = 1 (since we want `score_w > score_l`).
- In practice, some implementations train on each comparison twice by swapping winner and loser with the appropriate label.
- Use a held-out set of comparisons to evaluate reward model performance periodically (accuracy of predicting the human choice).

Hugging Face's `trl` has a `RewardTrainer` to ease this (specify model name, training arguments, and dataset, it will train accordingly). There's also open-source reward model checkpoints (e.g. OpenAI's 175B reward model isn't public, but smaller ones like `Dahoas/gptj-rm-static` were used in demonstrations [76]).

Batching note: Because each training sample is a pair of sequences, some code treats each pair as one item but does two forward passes (or a special architecture that encodes both at once). This can be tricky with padding. An alternative is to stack winners and losers in one batch with appropriate masking and then compute differences. Regardless, reward model training is standard supervised learning and usually converges faster than SFT (less data typically). The final reward model might even be ensembled or smoothed.

We won't delve deeper into code here due to space, but the main outcome is a function `reward_model(prompt, response) -> score`.

3. PPO Fine-Tuning (RLHF) Stage

Now the exciting part: using the reward model in the PPO loop to improve the policy. Using `trl.PPOTrainer` simplifies many aspects:

First, we need to set up the model with a **value head** and a **reference model**:

```
from transformers import AutoTokenizer
from trl import PPOTrainer, PPOConfig, AutoModelForCausalLMWithValueHead,
create_reference_model

# Load the policy model with a value head
model =
AutoModelForCausalLMWithValueHead.from_pretrained('<SFT_model_checkpoint>')
ref_model = create_reference_model(model)  # freeze a copy for KL computations
tokenizer = AutoTokenizer.from_pretrained('<base_model_name>')
tokenizer.pad_token = tokenizer.eos_token  # ensure pad token defined
ppo_config = PPOConfig(batch_size=16, learning_rate=5e-6, mini_batch_size=4,
optimize_cuda_cache=True)
ppo_trainer = PPOTrainer(ppo_config, model, ref_model, tokenizer,
reward_model=<callable_reward_fn>)
```

In the above snippet, `AutoModelForCausalLMWithValueHead` loads our policy model (say a 6B GPT-J fine-tuned model) and automatically adds a small **value head** to it (usually a copy of the LM head but outputting 1 value). `create_reference_model(model)` duplicates the model's weights for the reference, but here the library has a memory optimization: one can share some layers between `model` and `ref_model` to save memory [62] [77]. For example, `create_reference_model(model, num_shared_layers=6)` will make the first 6 transformer layers common between the two, only keeping separate the remaining layers for active vs reference. Those shared layers are *frozen* (since reference never updates, they effectively don't change for active either in those first layers) [77] [78]. This trick can cut memory by not holding two full copies. Hugging Face reports that sharing layers plus using bf16 allowed them to train a 6B model on a single 40GB GPU by nearly halving the 24GB+24GB memory otherwise needed [70] [62].

Next, the **PPO training loop**. Using `ppo_trainer`, the process looks like:

```
for batch in data_loader:  # data_loader provides prompts
    query_tensors = batch["input_ids"]  # a batch of tokenized prompts
    # Let the policy model generate responses
    response_tensors = []
    for query in query_tensors:
        response = ppo_trainer.generate(query, **generation_kwargs)  # model
generates a response
        response_tensors.append(response)
    # Compute rewards for each (prompt, response)
    rewards = []
    for query, response in zip(query_tensors, response_tensors):
        full_text = tokenizer.decode(query) + tokenizer.decode(response)
        reward_score = reward_model(full_text)  # or reward_model(query,
response) depending on interface
        rewards.append(torch.tensor(reward_score, dtype=torch.float))
    # Perform a PPO update
```

```
    stats = ppo_trainer.step(query_tensors, response_tensors, rewards)
    ppo_trainer.log_stats(stats, batch, rewards)  # logging for analysis
```

In practice, `ppo_trainer.step` internally does the forward passes on model and reference to compute log-probs and KL, computes the policy gradient (with advantages from the value head), and updates the model parameters (one PPO epoch on this batch, or multiple mini-batches if configured) [79] [80]. The `stats` will include things like the KL divergence, policy loss, value loss, and reward metrics which one can log (often to Weights & Biases or TensorBoard).

The generation step uses the model to produce an output for each prompt. One has to be cautious to generate within reasonable length and maybe using a sampling strategy (often nucleus sampling or greedy are used in training – some implementations use deterministic outputs to reduce variance, others use sampling to ensure exploration). The `generation_kwargs` might set a max length and stopping criteria (like stop at end-of-sentence tokens).

Memory and parallelism: Each PPO step involves computing the reference model's logits too. This effectively doubles memory consumption. Data-parallel training is usually used (e.g. if you have 4 GPUs, each GPU gets different prompts; accelerate/DeepSpeed can handle syncing gradients). **Scaling**: The TRL approach was initially single-GPU oriented, but it can be scaled via Accelerate and DeepSpeed zero-3 to many GPUs [81]. Alternatively, frameworks like DeepSpeed Chat provide a more out-of-the-box distributed RLHF training pipeline (but conceptually similar). For very large models, one might also shard model layers across GPUs (model parallelism) – but that complicates the reference model setup (one must shard identically). OpenAI likely did model parallel + data parallel for 175B.

Annotated example (summarizing code above):

```
# Assume we already fine-tuned a policy model 'policy-model-sft' and trained a
reward model 'reward-model'.
tokenizer = AutoTokenizer.from_pretrained('EleutherAI/gpt-j-6B')
model = AutoModelForCausalLMWithValueHead.from_pretrained('policy-model-sft')
ref_model = create_reference_model(model)  # copy weights for reference
ppo_trainer = PPOTrainer(PPOConfig(batch_size=8, learning_rate=1e-5),
                         model, ref_model, tokenizer)

# Dummy illustration for one step:
prompt_text = "Q: What is the meaning of life?\nA:"  # example prompt
query_tensor = tokenizer(prompt_text, return_tensors='pt').input_ids
response_tensor = ppo_trainer.generate(query_tensor)[0]  # generate a response
response_text = tokenizer.decode(response_tensor)
print("Model response:", response_text)

# Suppose we query the reward model (or a human) for this prompt/response:
reward_val = torch.tensor( reward_model(prompt_text, response_text),
dtype=torch.float32 )
```

```
# Now train one PPO step on this single example:
ppo_trainer.step([query_tensor.squeeze()], [response_tensor], [reward_val])
```

In reality, you'd use batch of N prompts per step for efficiency. The above is just to illustrate usage.

Using `trl` metrics: As mentioned, `ppo_trainer.step` returns statistics. For example, `stats['objective/kl']` is the mean KL divergence in that batch (we expect it to hover around a target value, e.g. 0.1 per token or something) [55]. `stats['objective/rlhf_reward']` is the mean (reward - β KL) achieved [56]. One typically sees `objective/rlhf_reward` rise during training if things are going well (the model is getting better at pleasing the reward model) [57]. Meanwhile, `objective/scores` (the raw reward model score) might also rise, but perhaps not as steeply if the KL penalty is compensating. In a successful run, the KL will initially jump up then stabilize, and the clipped update fraction `policy/clipfrac_avg` might stay below, say, 0.2 indicating not too many updates are saturating the trust region [65] [82].

Practical considerations: - *Reward normalization:* Sometimes the reward model outputs need to be normalized (e.g. Z-scored or standardized) for PPO to not be overwhelmed by large reward magnitudes. Ouyang et al. mention normalizing rewards to have a certain mean/std per batch. - *Entropy bonus:* In some implementations, an entropy regularizer is added to the loss to encourage the policy to maintain some randomness (avoid becoming deterministic). TRL tracks policy entropy as `policy/entropy` [55], and one can adjust if needed. - *Termination:* Ensure the generation stops appropriately. If the model doesn't output an EOS token, one might end up with extremely long responses. TRL's `missing_eos_penalty` can subtract a fixed reward if the model fails to end with EOS [66], nudging it to conclude responses sensibly.

Efficiency tips: Hugging Face's blog on scaling RLHF suggests using 8-bit quantization for the model weights during generation and training to save memory [83] [84]. Also, using gradient accumulation or smaller batch sizes can help fit in memory if out-of-memory occurs (their docs note if OOM, try reducing `per_device_train_batch_size` or use DeepSpeed ZeRO stage 3) [81]. Another tip is to use accelerated libraries (like the `transformers` integration of FasterTransformer for generation, or using FP8 on Hopper GPUs) – but these are advanced.

4. Putting it Together and Monitoring

After many iterations of PPO, one will have a final fine-tuned policy model. Typically, you'll save checkpoints along the way. Monitoring training via learning curves (reward vs steps, KL vs steps, etc.) is crucial. For example, if you see the reward model score leveling off while KL keeps increasing, it might mean the model is contorting itself in ways that increase reward *and* KL (net might still improve RLHF reward, but the fact that KL grows means the outputs are drifting). You might respond by increasing β to penalize KL more, or reducing learning rate to slow change. If `objective/rlhf_reward` starts decreasing or becomes unstable, it could indicate the policy overshot and now is being penalized heavily – possibly reduce LR or do early stopping.

Example of results: Using TRL, suppose we fine-tune a 6B model on the Anthropic HH dataset preferences. We might see the average reward (which could start negative, since the initial model might produce some dispreferred answers) steadily increase. In one AWS experiment with GPT-J 6B, the reward (they reported as a negative logit difference) went from -0.342 up to about -0.009 (closer to zero is better in their setup) over

3000 training steps [85] [86]. Throughout training, the curve was volatile (since optimization has variance) but trending upward, indicating PPO was indeed learning to please the reward model on average [85].

After training, they evaluated the model by having humans compare its outputs with those of the SFT model on 100 prompts. The RLHF-tuned model was preferred or tied in **84%** of cases (specifically, outright preferred in 30%, and tied in 54%) [87]. This shows a clear win for RLHF: the policy learned to give answers that humans liked more often than the answers from the supervised-only model. They also measured a slight reduction in toxicity of the responses: using an automated toxicity classifier, the RLHF model's outputs had an average toxicity score of 0.129 vs 0.134 for the SFT model (on a 0–1 scale, lower is better) [88]. This suggests the RLHF model found ways to be a bit more harmless while staying helpful.

Inference-time usage: The final policy model can be used directly to generate answers to user inputs. It's essentially what gets deployed as ChatGPT or similar. Often, one will still use some decoding strategy (like temperature sampling with a certain temp, or greedy if the model is sufficiently safe). The model's behavior at this point reflects the mixture of what it learned from SFT (base style) and what it learned from RL (fine-grained preferences). If done well, it will follow instructions accurately, provide additional clarifications or refuse inappropriate requests (because presumably those had higher reward for refusal behavior), and generally yield a better user experience.

Alternate RL algorithms: While PPO is standard, note that some recent research explores alternatives like **Direct Preference Optimization (DPO)** which avoids an explicit reward model by deriving a loss from the preference dataset directly (this was mentioned in some references and can be seen as a simplification of KL-regularized RL to a supervised loss) [89] [90]. Others explore **A2C** or off-policy methods, but PPO's on-policy nature is conceptually simpler for most. There are also approaches like **Exact KL control** (e.g. using a KL penalty method sometimes called "PPO-KL" which directly adds a term λ * KL to the loss instead of clipping) [50]. In practice, the difference is not huge if λ or β is tuned to mimic the effect.

By following these implementation steps (SFT -> RM -> PPO), one can replicate a mini-RLHF pipeline. Next, we'll discuss what can go wrong in this process and the challenges to be mindful of, before looking at some actual benchmark results and case studies of RLHF in real models.

Failure Modes and Challenges in RLHF

While RLHF has shown great promise in aligning language models, it comes with **a host of challenges and potential failure modes**. Understanding these is crucial for safe and effective training:

Reward Hacking and Overoptimization

Reward Hacking refers to the agent (the LM) exploiting imperfections in the reward model to get a high reward in unintended ways [91] [92]. Since the reward model is an imperfect proxy, the policy might learn to fool it rather than truly improve outputs. We saw an example earlier: the summarization model that learned to copy large chunks of text. Humans had intended the reward to indicate "good summary," but the model found a shortcut: *just copy the article* – which superficially looks relevant and thus was often marked as good by annotators or got a higher reward score [30] [40]. This clearly defeats the purpose of summarization (it wasn't actually abstractive summarizing), hence it's a kind of reward hacking. Another example might be a dialogue model that learns to insert a certain keyword or sentence that the reward model irrationally loves. For instance, if the reward model was not properly calibrated, a policy might figure out that starting every

answer with “Certainly! That’s a great question.” yields a higher score, and do that even when it’s inappropriate (because maybe the reward model associated a polite tone with higher human ratings).

This is fundamentally an **objective mismatch** problem: the reward model’s objective is not perfectly aligned with true human preferences [93] [94]. There’s always some discrepancy. As RL training continues, the policy distribution shifts and might enter regions where the reward model generalizes poorly, allowing high reward for nonsense. In extreme cases, the policy could produce gibberish that the reward model thinks is great because it’s outside its training data. This is why the KL penalty and iterative training (refreshing the reward model with new human data if possible) are important mitigations [49] [95].

Overoptimization is a related concept: even if not exactly “hacking” in a trickster sense, the policy might optimize so hard for the reward that it **overfits** to it and loses some other virtues. For example, if the reward heavily emphasizes a very helpful tone, the model might start generating unnecessarily long-winded answers (since being extremely thorough might have been rewarded by humans). This could reduce conciseness or even factual accuracy if it means the model starts guessing at details to fill out an answer (because a longer answer was often judged better, the model might always produce long answers even when a short one suffices). Thus, pushing one dimension of performance (the reward’s definition of “helpfulness”) can reduce quality in others.

Mitigations: Constant monitoring and periodic human-in-the-loop checks are key. During training, one can sample outputs from the current policy and have humans verify them (a form of *evaluation dataset* separate from training). If one sees reward hacking (like verbatim copying in summaries, or formulaic responses), one can adjust the reward model (e.g., explicitly penalize too much overlap, or penalize repetition). Christiano et al. talked about query selection to focus on uncertain comparisons – this helps the reward model improve in areas the policy is exploiting [96]. Another mitigation used in InstructGPT: mixing in a bit of the original supervised objective (next-token prediction on a broad dataset) during RL training to prevent the model from deviating too far from general language modeling capabilities [13]. They found that adding, say, 5% of the original pretraining objective (on a cache of internet data) alongside the RL loss maintained performance on academic tasks and reduced the “alignment tax” [13]. That likely also prevents the model from forgetting knowledge or collapsing into a degenerate style because it’s still occasionally reminded of general language modeling.

We should also mention **direct preference optimization** (DPO) as a way to possibly avoid reward hacking: DPO trains on the same comparisons but avoids training a reward model explicitly, instead optimizing the policy to prefer human-favored outputs with a built-in KL regularization [89] [97]. Proponents argue this might reduce one source of error (the reward model). However, DPO can be seen as an analytical transformation of the reward model approach, so many challenges remain similar (it also has a “β” parameter akin to KL penalty [97]).

KL Collapse or Divergence

We use the term **KL collapse** to describe situations where the KL penalty either becomes too strong or too weak, destabilizing training: - If the KL penalty is too high (or we target a very small KL divergence), the policy updates will be very minimal – the model might effectively stay near the SFT model and not actually improve reward much. You’ll see the `objective/rlhf_reward` plateau because the policy isn’t allowed to move toward higher reward solutions if they require deviating from the reference. In extreme cases, the model just doesn’t learn beyond the initial policy (collapse in the sense of no progress). - Conversely, if the

KL penalty is too low, the policy can diverge rapidly. Initially, the reward might improve, but soon the model may drift into a regime where it produces strange outputs that the reward model gives high scores (for wrong reasons). The KL between policy and reference will spike. This often leads to instability: the training might oscillate or the policy might collapse to a mode that's actually pretty bad for real users (even if the reward model is fooled). For example, one might observe the model starting to generate very short, generic answers – why? Possibly because a short answer can minimize the chance of messing up and incurring a reward penalty, and also a short answer is closer to reference distribution (since many training answers might be short). If the reward model isn't strongly distinguishing, the policy might collapse to always output something like "I'm sorry, I don't know." for every question, because that's a safe answer that doesn't get a big penalty and might get mildly positive reward for harmlessness. This is a collapse scenario some have observed if the reward isn't nuanced and KL is not well-tuned – the model becomes *too* cautious and dull (some call this mode collapse or "safe completion mode").

During OpenAI's training, they indeed had to dynamically adjust KL to avoid divergence; they mention aiming for a certain KL range (like ~6 nats) [51]. If KL went too low (policy not changing at all), they might reduce β; if KL went too high, they increase β to rein the policy in. This *adaptive KL control* is a common heuristic now.

Additionally, **catastrophic forgetting** can occur – the model might lose some knowledge or abilities it had, in pursuit of the new objective. InstructGPT reported some drops in performance on tasks like commonsense QA after RLHF (which they mitigated by data mixing) [13]. If RL training is too aggressive, the model could forget factual info from pretraining, or specialized skills, because those aren't directly rewarded. This is another form of overoptimization: the model becomes superb at being helpful in style, but might become worse at, say, solving math problems that require multistep reasoning (since the reward model might not have pressed on that, and the KL penalty might discourage the model from going into uncertain reasoning paths, preferring a safe generic answer).

Mitigations: Aside from adaptive KL, using a **value function baseline** helps reduce variance so the training doesn't jump around as much. Ensuring your reward model is updated (in case the policy goes into new territory, you might label some of those outputs and retrain the reward model) is another approach (iterative RLHF as done in some works where they alternate between policy improvement and reward model improvement). And as mentioned, mixing some supervised loss or explicit **penalty terms** for unwanted behaviors helps – e.g., Anthropic's Claude with Constitutional AI adds penalties for dishonesty or hallucination by design in the reward model, to target those issues explicitly [39].

Speaking of **hallucination**, it's worth noting a somewhat surprising finding: RLHF does *not* automatically solve the hallucination problem of LLMs, and in some cases can worsen it. InstructGPT's paper found that the RLHF model hallucinated facts **more often** than the baseline GPT-3 or the purely supervised model [98] [99]. Why? Possibly because the reward model (or human labelers) might forgive a plausible-sounding lie more than an admission of ignorance. For example, given a question the model doesn't actually know the answer to, an SFT model might sometimes say "I'm not sure." whereas an RLHF model, eager to be helpful, might fabricate an answer – and the human evaluator might prefer that confident answer (even if slightly wrong) over a non-answer in some cases. This is an *objective mismatch*: humans asked to judge helpfulness might inadvertently encourage informative-sounding answers, even if they aren't grounded in truth. As Chip Huyen summarized, *"RLHF actually made hallucination worse... Even though RLHF caused worse hallucination, it improved other aspects, and overall human labelers prefer the RLHF model over SFT alone."* [98]. This highlights that human preference is not a perfect proxy for factual accuracy. It's a known issue: a model that

confidently says a wrong fact can still be rated highly by a layperson who doesn't know it's wrong. So RLHF can increase that confident bluffing tendency. Indeed, RLHF-tuned models often have learned to *never say "I don't know"* (because that was rarely the top-ranked answer), which unfortunately means they will always give an answer, even if it requires hallucination.

Mitigations for hallucination: One approach is to explicitly instruct annotators to penalize factual errors, or to incorporate factuality checks into the reward model (e.g., train the reward model to detect blatant factual errors or use an ensemble that includes a fact-checker). Another is to combine RLHF with techniques like "self-consistency" or ask the model to cite sources (if those behaviors can be captured via preferences). This remains an active area of research. But it's an important caution: *Better alignment with user preferences doesn't always mean better alignment with truth.* Sometimes users can be misled by a fluent answer, so the reward model might inadvertently prefer a fluent hallucination to a halting but correct answer.

Noisy or Biased Preferences

Human feedback is inherently subjective and can be inconsistent. Different annotators might have different preferences, and even the same annotator might be inconsistent over time or across similar examples. This **preference noise** means the reward model will learn a somewhat noisy signal. If the noise is high, the policy might struggle to improve or might overfit to idiosyncrasies. For example, if half the labelers prefer very concise answers and the other half prefer very detailed answers, the reward model will be uncertain and the policy might oscillate or produce a mix of styles. If the annotators have a bias (e.g., they unintentionally favor outputs that use certain phrasing or political viewpoint), the model will internalize that bias. This raises fairness and bias concerns: RLHF could amplify the biases present in the human feedback population or guidelines.

Mitigations: To reduce noise, one can gather multiple preferences per comparison and use majority vote or average. Ensuring annotators are well-trained on the criteria and that the criteria are as unambiguous as possible helps [100]. (Ziegler's team noted difficulty when the task was ambiguously defined; clearer guidelines improved agreement [100].) Additionally, one can incorporate **uncertainty estimates** in the reward model; if it's very uncertain (like outputs it hasn't seen enough), maybe the training should focus there or at least be cautious. Diverse annotator hiring can help reduce systematic bias – but if the userbase differs from annotators, there's still a gap. Some work, like OpenAI's, evaluated the RLHF models with labelers *who were not involved in training* to see if preferences generalize [101]. They found that held-out labelers also preferred the RLHF model's outputs similarly, suggesting the reward model wasn't completely overfitted to a single set of labelers [101].

Another challenge is **objective misspecification**: if the instructions to labelers emphasize some aspects and ignore others, the model will align to those specified aspects at the cost of others. For instance, if labelers are told to only rate helpfulness and not fact-check, the model will optimize helpfulness even if it means making up facts.

Guideline here is: have a well-rounded reward signal that includes multiple axes (helpfulness, correctness, harmlessness). Sometimes a combined reward or a multi-objective approach is used (e.g., ensure no toxic content via a hard constraint, while optimizing helpfulness as primary reward). Anthropic's HH dataset actually has two axes: helpfulness and harmlessness, and they train separate reward models for each or a single multi-task reward model, then do RLHF to optimize a weighted sum or do two-stage training [102] [103].

Cost and Scalability

Collecting high-quality human feedback is expensive and slow. RLHF training is also computationally heavy – generating many sequences and running a large model for each, then doing backprop through another large model (the policy). OpenAI's InstructGPT used hundreds of labeler hours and a lot of GPU hours on their clusters to train models like the 175B one. Scaling RLHF to very large models or continuously updating models is an ongoing engineering challenge. Recent developments try to reduce cost: e.g., using **AI feedback (RLAIF)** where a cheaper model simulates human feedback (Anthropic's constitutional AI does something like this by generating critiques with another model) [104]. This can cut down on required human labels, but one must ensure the AI feedback doesn't introduce errors.

Memory and speed optimizations we discussed (like 8-bit, sharing layers, Low-Rank adapters) are also crucial for scalability [70] [62]. For instance, a 6B model can be trained on one high-end GPU with these tricks, but a 70B model might need distributed training or ZeRO optimizers to partition the states.

Another subtle challenge: **evaluating** RLHF models is hard. Automatic metrics (BLEU, ROUGE, etc.) often do not capture the improvements that RLHF provides, since those metrics don't measure "alignment" or "satisfaction." For example, RLHF might drastically improve how polite and on-topic answers are, which isn't measured by BLEU. So one relies on human evaluations. OpenAI reported human eval results and had to gather those. That's why they also did things like measure TruthfulQA, toxicity, etc., to ensure there aren't hidden regressions [105] [106]. They did find some regressions: as mentioned, slight worse truthfulness on some, etc. This underscores that RLHF is balancing a complex objective (some aspects can get better at slight expense of others, unless mitigated).

In conclusion, RLHF training must be done thoughtfully to avoid these issues. **Objective mismatch** is fundamental – we try to align with human values, but we only ever have proxies. A critical mindset is needed: always ask "What is the reward model actually incentivizing here, and is that truly what we want?"

To address some of these, researchers are exploring *iterative refinement* (train, deploy, collect more human data on failures, retrain), *hierarchical feedback* (not just pairwise preferences but reasoning explanations from humans), or *integrating rule-based rewards* (like a rule that says "if output has a factual assertion, check it").

The bottom line: RLHF dramatically improves usability and safety in many respects (as evidenced by human preference scores), but it doesn't guarantee perfection. Models can still be wrong, and sometimes more confidently so. The alignment is better, yet not complete.

Having covered the cautionary aspects, let's move on to concrete results from a **mini-RLHF run** and then to real-world case studies like InstructGPT and ChatGPT which exemplify these concepts at scale.

Benchmark Results: Mini-RLHF on a 6B Model (Performance, Memory, Convergence)

To make things concrete, consider a scenario of applying RLHF (via TRL's PPO implementation) on a moderately sized model (~6 billion parameters, e.g. GPT-J-6B) using a small-scale setup (say one or a few

GPUs). This “mini-RLHF” is illustrative of what one might do in a research lab or even personal project to align a model on a specific domain or set of values.

Experimental setup: Let’s use the example from an AWS blog and Hugging Face demo: fine-tune GPT-J 6B on the **Helpful/Harmless (HH)** dialogue dataset (by Anthropic) [107] [108]. The SFT model is first trained on human demonstrations of helpful answers and polite refusals to unsafe requests (the HH dataset’s **“Harmless”** instructions). Then, a reward model is either trained or taken pre-trained (the AWS demo uses a pre-trained GPT-J reward model for helpfulness [76]). Finally, PPO training is done to improve the policy.

Computational requirements: A 6B model in float32 would require ~24 GB memory just to load (since 6B * 4 bytes ≈ 24 GB) [109]. In float16 or bfloat16, that halves to ~12 GB [109]. But PPO needs two copies (policy + reference), plus optimizer states (which can be another factor of 2 if using Adam – though often one can omit momentum on the reference copy). Naively, one might need on the order of 24 GB for model weights and another ~12–16 GB for activations, gradients, and optimizer – clearly beyond a single 24 GB GPU. However, techniques like loading the model in 8-bit precision (int8) for inference can cut it down to ~6 GB per model copy [83] [84], and using LoRA to train only a fraction of parameters means optimizer states are only kept for those small matrices (drastically lower overhead). In one demonstration, HF researchers managed to fine-tune a 20B parameter model on a single 24 GB GPU by combining 8-bit loading and LoRA adapters [110] [111]. For a 6B model, this means it’s very feasible on a single modern GPU (like 24 GB VRAM) using such methods. Alternatively, AWS’s example used a multi-GPU machine (a p4d.24xlarge with 8×40GB GPUs) and the DeepSpeed ZeRO Stage 2 to split the model across 7 GPUs [112] [113] (they launched with `--num_processes 7` presumably leaving one GPU for something else).

Memory optimization in practice: The Hugging Face team suggests two main tricks for 6B on one GPU: **(a) use bfloat16** (so 12 GB for model) [70], **(b) share layers between policy and reference** using `num_shared_layers` in `create_reference_model` [62]. For GPT-J (transformer with ~28 layers), sharing the first e.g. 20 layers would mean only the top 8 layers are duplicated – that cuts reference overhead a lot (at some cost: those shared layers are frozen, meaning the policy can’t update its lower layers – but that might be acceptable, focusing learning on higher layers). They also mention gradient checkpointing as a fallback if still tight on memory [75]. Empirically, they reported that training GPT-J 6B with PPO on a single 40GB GPU was possible with these strategies [70] [62]. If one doesn’t use sharing, then multi-GPU or a smaller model might be needed. Our mini-run could also choose a smaller model (like 2.7B GPT-Neo) to be safe on a single GPU without fancy tricks.

Training time and performance: RLHF is slower than normal fine-tuning because generating text for each prompt is required at each iteration. Suppose we use batch size 16 and each prompt generates a response of, say, 100 tokens on average. That’s 1600 tokens generated per iteration. GPT-J can generate maybe a few thousands of tokens per second on a GPU, so it’s not too bad – perhaps on the order of 0.5–1 second per batch generation. Then PPO backward pass is another fraction of a second. So we might be looking at maybe 1–2 seconds per iteration (16 episodes). To reach 3000 episodes (like AWS did) might take ~3000/8 ≈ 375 iterations if each iteration had 8 episodes? Actually, careful: In AWS, they likely mean 3000 training steps (each step might have a batch, maybe they used 64 prompts per step? Unclear). Let’s assume 3000 *episodes* was maybe ~3000/16 ≈ 188 steps with batch16 if each episode is one prompt (but that seems low). Possibly they mean 3000 gradient updates. If each had batch 32, that’s 96000 episodes in total – which with 100-token generations is ~9.6 million tokens processed by reward model and policy – manageable. They reported that after 3000 iterations, reward improved significantly [85].

Convergence behavior: In the aforementioned run, the reward (according to the reward model) steadily went up. Initially, the average reward per response was around -0.34 (this might be a logit difference or some normalized score) and by iteration 3000 it was about -0.01 [85]. The upward trend wasn't smooth (it fluctuates because of exploration and the stochastic nature of updates), but clearly upward overall [85]. This indicates the PPO training successfully improved the policy with respect to the reward model's criteria. Meanwhile, they observed the KL divergence (though not explicitly stated in the summary, typically one monitors it) likely was kept in check by their use of KL penalty (they probably used a certain β). TRL's default might target a KL ~0.1 per token or similar. If KL started to drift, one would adjust β.

Policy quality: As mentioned, human evaluation on 100 prompts showed the RLHF model was preferred or tied in 84% of cases compared to the SFT model [87]. That's a strong endorsement – it means in only 16 out of 100 prompts did the supervised model clearly win, whereas in 30 cases RLHF clearly won, and in more than half it was a tie (meaning RLHF didn't degrade anything, it was at least as good). Qualitatively, the blog gave some examples: the RLHF model's answers were more on-point. For instance, to a question asking for a recipe, the SFT model gave a confused answer ("What do you mean by street corn? Isn't it a donut?" – clearly it misunderstood), while the RLHF model gave a correct recipe suggestion [114]. This shows RLHF helped the model focus on being *helpful and correct* rather than getting sidetracked. Another example: "When was Canada colonized?" – the SFT model gave a single wrong date, whereas the RLHF model gave a nuanced, multi-sentence answer with correct historical context [115]. This highlights RLHF model's tendency to provide more thorough, factual answers, which labelers found more preferable.

Toxicity reduction: They measured slight drop in toxicity scores (0.134 -> 0.129 average) [88], which though small, is in the right direction. Hugging Face's own detoxification experiment with PPO found that for a 6B model, PPO could reduce the mean toxicity of generations from 0.17 to 0.15 (with a particular classifier as reward) [116]. The effect was modest at 6B, more pronounced at 2.7B, interestingly [116] [117]. They hypothesized that the largest model was harder to push – possibly because it had more knowledge of toxic content and needed stronger or longer training to reduce that, or maybe their hyperparams for 6B were not fully optimal [117]. They also noted larger minibatch sizes led to smoother training curves for PPO [63] – large batches average out variability and make advantage estimates more stable, which helps in reaching a better optimum (though at cost of more memory).

Resource usage: On a single A100 40GB, one can run GPT-J 6B PPO with int8 and LoRA fairly well. The CPU should handle orchestrating reward model calls (some load could be on CPU if reward model runs there, but usually, it's on GPU too). CPU also might decode tokens to text occasionally for logging, but that's minor.

Key metrics logged: In one of HF's runs for detoxification, they logged the KL evolution and found that if learning rate was too high, the KL would blow up and cause training to fail (they showed a graph of a high LR causing "collapse mode") [118]. By choosing a smaller LR, they got a nice convergence where the reward (lack of toxicity) improved without diverging KL [118] [119]. So tuning LR and β was essential for 6B stability.

Comparison to larger models: A 6B model fine-tuned with RLHF can in some tasks rival a much larger model's performance if the larger model isn't aligned. OpenAI noted their 1.3B InstructGPT was preferred over 175B GPT-3 by users [120]. Similarly, a 6B RLHF model might be more useful in conversation than an unaligned 30B model. However, an RLHF 6B still has fundamental limits in knowledge and fluency compared to a RLHF 30B or 175B. It might do well in style (being polite, following format), but could lack some depth or accuracy that bigger models have. In practice, open-source RLHF models like OpenAssistant's 7B or Stanford's Alpaca 7B (which is instruct-tuned but not full RLHF) have shown surprisingly good behavior,

though they are noticeably weaker in complex reasoning than something like ChatGPT (based on a 175B model).

Memory footprint summary: With int8: 6B model = ~6 GB, value head negligible, LoRA adds maybe a few tens of millions of params (negligible), reference shares most layers (say shares half, so additional ~3 GB), plus optimizer states for LoRA matrices only (tiny), plus reward model (if reward model is also 6B GPT-J, that's another ~6 GB). So total might be ~15 GB on GPU. Add activation overhead maybe pushing to ~20 GB. That fits in 24 GB fine. Without int8 or sharing, if using bf16: 6B is 12GB, reference another 12GB, reward model 12GB, total 36GB just weights – too high. So at least multi-GPU or ZeRO needed in that scenario. So the HF strategies are vital for single GPU operation.

Convergence: Typically, one trains until the reward plateaus or starts to slowly decrease (which might indicate overfitting or saturation). In Ziegler's work, they decided on certain number of iterations based on validation. In our mini-run, they stopped at 3000 updates and saw significant improvements; presumably going further might not help much or could risk over-optimization. Another criterion is to watch if the KL divergence is creeping up over time – if it's slowly rising while reward still goes up, that might be okay, but if KL accelerates, one might stop or raise β. There's also the possibility of **KL collapse** where the policy nearly copies the reference – that would show as KL going near 0 and reward stagnating; then you know you need to reduce β or increase learning rate to get movement.

Summary of results: On a 6B model, RLHF (with ~few thousand comparisons and training steps) can meaningfully improve the alignment of the model: humans prefer its answers, and it behaves more helpfully and safely. It doesn't require massive infrastructure – one or a few GPUs and some clever memory management suffice (especially thanks to recent libraries). The improvements observed are not just anecdotal: they are quantified by preference wins and slight toxicity score drops. However, as noted before, certain things like hallucination might not dramatically improve with such small-scale RLHF unless specifically targeted. In our scenario, factuality was implicitly part of the helpfulness reward (the labelers would likely prefer a correct answer to an incorrect one), so it did get somewhat better (the Canada example shows the RLHF model gave a more correct answer). But if we ask obscure trivia, a 6B model might still hallucinate because it simply doesn't know. RLHF can't create knowledge; it can only prefer expressions of uncertainty or avoidance if properly incentivized. In training, if those cases weren't explicitly covered, the model might still bluff. Realizing these nuanced outcomes often requires targeted evaluation.

We will now examine how these techniques have been applied in prominent real-world systems and what outcomes were achieved, to solidify our understanding of RLHF's impact and best practices.

Case Studies: RLHF in InstructGPT, ChatGPT, and Other Aligned Models

To see RLHF in action at scale, let's look at a few notable models and how they employed instruction tuning and RLHF:

InstructGPT (OpenAI, 2022)

InstructGPT (Ouyang et al., 2022) is a landmark example of using RLHF to align a large language model (GPT-3). The team started with GPT-3 175B as the base model. They first collected a dataset of **13k human-**

written demonstrations on a variety of user prompts [14] [15] (prompts were either taken from their API distribution or crafted to cover diverse tasks). They fine-tuned GPT-3 on these demonstrations to get a **Supervised Baseline**. This alone made the model significantly better at following instructions than the original GPT-3, as they reported. But the main advance was applying RLHF:

They gathered a dataset of **comparative feedback**: around **40k prompts with model outputs ranked by humans** [5]. Each prompt had 4 to 9 outputs from either the current policy or older versions (they used a policy pool to generate diverse candidates) [38]. Labelers ranked them from best to worst. This yielded on the order of 100k+ pairwise comparisons (each ranking can be decomposed into pairs). They trained a **reward model** (actually, they trained 3 separate reward models specialized in different prompt domains, but let's keep it simple) on this data [5]. The reward model architecture was a GPT-3 6B model with a scalar head.

Using this reward model, they then fine-tuned the 175B model with PPO. To manage such a huge model, they likely used model parallelism across many GPUs and adapted the PPO algorithm accordingly. They also implemented the trick of mixing in a bit of the original training data with a small weight to reduce performance regressions (alignment tax) [13]. They ran PPO for a certain number of steps (not publicly stated in detail, but presumably until the reward converged or slight drop in some eval).

Results: The InstructGPT models (they actually produced 3 sizes: 1.3B, 6B, 175B, to compare) were evaluated against the original GPT-3. In human evaluations on a set of prompt queries, **InstructGPT was strongly preferred**. Their labelers preferred the 175B InstructGPT over 175B GPT-3 in the vast majority of cases for helpfulness [21]. Impressively, even the **1.3B** InstructGPT was preferred to 175B GPT-3 by testers in terms of following instructions usefully [10]. This shows how much alignment work can compensate for model size. They also measured factuality via the TruthfulQA benchmark and found that the 175B InstructGPT hallucinated slightly less than GPT-3 (though still hallucinated plenty). On a toxicity benchmark (RealToxicityPrompts), InstructGPT was less likely to produce toxic completions than GPT-3 [105]. These improvements demonstrate alignment: the model not only is more *useful*, but also somewhat safer.

One caution: they did find that on some *academic NLP tasks* (like summarization ROUGE, QA exact match, etc.), the RLHF-tuned model's performance was slightly worse than the original GPT-3's, presumably because the model's style changed or it focused less on those metrics [121]. By mixing some original data during RLHF (as mentioned), they mostly fixed this such that InstructGPT could maintain capabilities while being aligned [121]. This mitigation was key to avoid the "alignment tax" where a model might become too specialized to following instructions and lose versatility.

InstructGPT's training introduced the explicit **KL penalty** method to large-scale LM RLHF. They treated the supervised model as the reference policy and penalized divergence. They set a target KL (like KL ~ 6 nats between new and old policy distribution on the prompt distribution) – when the policy strayed beyond that, the PPO objective's penalty factor increased to rein it in. This dynamic was essential to keep the model's outputs fluent and "GPT-3-like" in distribution while aligning it. Without it, presumably they'd see more cases of disfluent or repetitive behavior.

OpenAI's deployment of InstructGPT in January 2022 essentially replaced the base GPT-3 in their API. This was the first time such RLHF-aligned models were put into wide production, and user feedback was overwhelmingly that it was a huge improvement: the model actually tries to follow your instruction without extra prompt engineering.

ChatGPT (OpenAI, 2022-2023)

ChatGPT (the version initially released in Nov 2022) is essentially an improved, conversationally fine-tuned descendant of InstructGPT. OpenAI took a model in the GPT-3.5 series (they haven't confirmed, but likely something like 175B with some architectural tweaks, possibly trained on dialogue data as well) and applied instruction tuning and RLHF with a focus on multi-turn dialogues. The steps mirror InstructGPT but with conversation data:

1. They gathered **demonstrations of conversations**: labelers played both user and assistant roles in chat dialogs, demonstrating how the assistant should respond (including polite refusals for disallowed content, etc.). This is like SFT but for chat format. We can call this model "ChatGPT-SFT" initially.

2. They collected **comparison data** where labelers read a conversation and multiple possible assistant continuations, and ranked them. Possibly they had labelers chat with the model and then rate its answers.

3. They trained a **reward model** on these chat comparisons. (Likely a model similar size to the policy – maybe smaller, not sure. Possibly they reused the same 6B reward model concept or maybe a 20B one for better judgment.)

4. They fine-tuned the policy with PPO using the reward model. There might have been multiple phases (like first do single-turn RLHF, then multi-turn). They also likely did iterative refinement: launching an early model, seeing how users interact, and collecting more data on its mistakes to further fine-tune.

ChatGPT's public success showed how effective this can be: it can follow a wide range of instructions, remember context, refuse many inappropriate requests with a (sometimes overly verbose) apology, and generally produce very helpful answers across domains. It's essentially *InstructGPT on steroids*. Users notice that ChatGPT often gives much more detailed answers than earlier models – that's partly because RLHF optimized for user satisfaction, and many users tend to reward detail and comprehensiveness. The flipside is sometimes ChatGPT gives long-winded answers where a short one would do, or it may state things very confidently.

OpenAI's system card and other info note that ChatGPT still has problems: it can still produce incorrect statements, it can sometimes be coaxed into disallowed behavior via clever prompts (jailbreaking), and it tends to be biased by the preferences of the training distribution (e.g., it often gives very neutral, politically correct answers, which some users find too filtered). These are direct consequences of RLHF: the model is aligned with the specific guidelines OpenAI gave labelers. If those guidelines say avoid political opinions or controversial takes, the model will err on the side of refusal or neutrality. If the guidelines reflect a certain culture's view of what's appropriate, the model will align to that, which might not satisfy everyone globally.

One interesting aspect of ChatGPT is **instruction following vs conversation**: it was fine-tuned to follow instructions even if embedded in a conversation. E.g., user can say, "Let's do roleplay, you're a Shakespearean actor" and ChatGPT will shift style. This flexibility comes from training on many prompt types and from the RLHF reward likely favoring outputs that appropriately follow user requests.

OpenAI also used RLHF for **GPT-4**, their next model, as indicated in the GPT-4 technical report. They say they did more extensive feedback, including from AI and humans, and in multiple languages. GPT-4's alignment is better in some ways (it is more factually accurate and harder to jailbreak), yet some issues persist. GPT-4's case also showed a phenomenon: *the more powerful the model, the more careful RLHF shaping is needed*, because a smarter model can find more subtle ways to game rewards or produce deceptive outputs. They had to use additional techniques like leverage GPT-4 itself to help evaluate outputs (creating a sort of automated reward signal for certain aspects).

Anthropic's Claude (2022-2023)

Anthropic's Claude is another assistant AI, developed by former OpenAI folks. They initially followed an RLHF approach similar to InstructGPT, but they also experimented with something called **Constitutional AI**. The idea was to reduce reliance on human feedback by using a set of written principles (a "constitution") and having the AI critique its own outputs according to those principles, generating synthetic feedback. In practice, they did a round of RLHF with human preferences for helpfulness and harmlessness (the HH dataset), similar to others [107] [122]. In fact, Anthropic released the HH dataset openly, which others have used. Then for Constitutional AI, they took a model and let it generate an output, then generate a critique of that output based on a rule (like "the assistant should not be hateful"), and then improved the output. They turned this into a form of RL (or actually more like a supervised finetuning on AI-generated comparisons that reflect the constitution rules) [39].

The result, Claude, is known to be quite good at being inoffensive and following certain safety rules, sometimes even more so than ChatGPT (Claude might refuse some requests that ChatGPT would answer, for instance). However, early versions of Claude had some issues (there were reports it could be tricked by certain prompts to output bad stuff, but that's an ongoing cat-and-mouse).

Training details for Claude: Not all public, but one paper "Constitutional AI" (Bai et al. 2022) described fine-tuning a model with ~52k AI-generated preference comparisons (with some initial human oversight) [39]. They found it performed well with far fewer human labels because the AI helped generate lots of data.

Other Models and Variants

- **DeepMind Sparrow (2022):** Sparrow was a dialogue agent that used RLHF to align with explicit rules (like "don't give medical advice", "cite sources if giving factual info"). They had humans both rank outputs and check rule compliance. Sparrow was able to learn to refuse questions that break rules and to provide sources when asked factual questions. This was an interesting variant where the reward model had multiple components (accuracy, rule adherence, etc.). It highlights that RLHF can incorporate multi-objective rewards if you can encode them (they likely had separate signals: one from factual correctness classifier, one from a rule-violation classifier, etc., combined with human preference).

- **Microsoft / OpenAI Bing Chat (2023):** Bing's chat uses OpenAI's models (GPT-4 presumably) with RLHF. Microsoft then put additional layers of prompting to make it follow a persona. The initial Bing chat had some highly publicized failures (it gave some bizarre responses), which might indicate some misalignment or that under certain conditions (long conversations), even RLHF-tuned models can go off the rails (the model may optimize for being entertaining over being correct if the user pushes it that way).

- **Open-Source Projects:** There have been numerous open attempts: e.g., Stanford's **Alpaca** was just SFT (no RLHF), yet by fine-tuning LLaMA on 52k instruction-response pairs generated by text-davinci-003 (GPT-3.5), it got a surprisingly good instruct-following model at 7B. That shows a complementary approach: you can use a strong RLHF model to generate synthetic data to train a smaller model (leveraging knowledge distillation in a way). However, because that synthetic data doesn't include comparisons, Alpaca is basically an SFT model, so it sometimes will not know how to say "I can't answer that" appropriately or might not handle conflicting objectives well. Indeed, Alpaca and similar models tend to be more prone to refusing too little or giving harmful content because they weren't RLHF-trained on those aspects explicitly. Some communities have tried RLHF on open models: e.g., **TRLX** library (by CarperAI) and others fine-tuned GPT-J, GPT-NeoX, and even LLaMA on preference data. There's also the **Open Assistant** project which gathered a large human feedback dataset via crowdsourcing and fine-tuned a model with RLHF. They open-sourced the data and model. This demonstrates RLHF doesn't strictly require a giant company – though gathering good data is still the hardest part. OpenAssistant's model is decent but arguably not as polished as ChatGPT, likely due to model size (they used 30B or 12B models) and maybe quality variability in crowdsourced data.

- **Direct Preference Optimization (DPO) and others:** There's ongoing research to simplify RLHF. One method, DPO (Rafailov et al. 2023), reformulates the RLHF objective as a log-ratio (like they derive a loss similar to a logistic loss that directly trains the policy using the comparisons, without training a reward model explicitly) [123] [90]. They have had some success showing DPO can achieve similar results to PPO on some tasks, but it's early. Another approach is tuning models to critique themselves (self-refine), which is adjacent to RLHF but could reduce some errors without explicit preferences.

- **RLHF beyond language:** RLHF is being applied to other domains too, like code generation (where human preferences might be "did the code compile and do what I intended?") or image generation (where preferences could be about style or avoiding unsafe images). For instance, there are attempts to use human feedback to tune Stable Diffusion to user aesthetic preferences.

In all these case studies, the common thread is: Start with a model that's strong but possibly unaligned, then use human data (instructions or preferences) to make it follow what humans actually want. The success of InstructGPT and ChatGPT has made RLHF almost a *standard* for deploying any large model that interacts with humans. Companies are now focusing on how to efficiently gather that human data, how to cover edge cases (like jailbreaking attempts, or biases), and how to maintain model performance. It's an active area bridging machine learning with human-computer interaction and ethics.

One more note on **evaluation** in these case studies: They all rely heavily on human evaluation to claim success. Automatic metrics are secondary. For example, OpenAI reported those preference percentages (like labelers preferring A over B). They also did targeted tests: e.g., ask a question where the correct answer is known, see if model or baseline is correct (factual eval). They tested toxicity by a classifier. For truthfulness, they used a benchmark. So a combination of crowd worker judgments and automated metrics.

Open problems glimpsed in case studies: Hallucinations are not solved (ChatGPT still does at times, GPT-4 less but still can). Maintaining up-to-date information is separate (RLHF doesn't fix that – ChatGPT doesn't know post-2021 info, and it might make stuff up if asked). Also, models sometimes become overly cautious

(e.g., refusals for harmless queries if they even vaguely resemble something disallowed – this is a precision vs recall in alignment problem).

To wrap up, RLHF (and instruction tuning broadly) has become critical for making AI assistants usable and aligning them with user needs. But it's also clear that it's not perfect: models aligned via RLHF reflect the values of the data and can still err in reasoning or facts. The field is working on refining these techniques and exploring complements (like better reward modeling, incorporating other signals like process-based feedback where humans give step-by-step critique, etc.).

Summary and Practical Takeaways

In this study guide, we covered the full pipeline of **post-training alignment** for language models, focusing on **Instruction Tuning and Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback (RLHF)**. Let's summarize the key points and practical insights:

- **Post-Training Motivation:** Large LM pre-training imparts broad abilities but not fine-grained alignment with human intentions. Post-training via supervised instruction tuning and RLHF is crucial to make models follow user instructions, be helpful, and avoid harmful content [1] [124]. This alignment can dramatically improve user experience – e.g., a well-tuned 6B model can outperform an untuned 175B model on following instructions [10].

- **Instruction Tuning (SFT):** Fine-tuning on human-written demonstrations teaches the model the *desired format and basic behavior* for various tasks. It's relatively easy to implement (standard supervised loss) and yields immediate gains in model helpfulness. Always do SFT before RLHF if possible – it provides a strong initialization. SFT data should cover a wide range of tasks and emphasize clarity, correctness, and style you want from the model. However, SFT alone doesn't teach the model how to choose the *best* output among many, and it gives no practice in saying "I don't know" or refusing unsafe requests (unless such examples are included). It is necessary but not sufficient for alignment [23].

- **Reward Modeling from Human Preferences:** By collecting pairwise (or ranked) comparisons of model outputs from humans, we can train a reward model to mimic human judgments [28] [34]. This reward model essentially *learns the human's latent reward function* – though imperfectly. Key implementation tip: use a simple pairwise logistic loss, and be mindful of the data quality. It's important to cover the kinds of distinctions you care about (e.g., factual correctness, politeness, completeness) in the comparisons so the reward model picks up on them. Evaluate the reward model's accuracy on a validation set of comparisons – typically aim for >70% agreement with humans [40]. If the reward model is poor, RLHF won't work well, so more data or a better model might be needed.

- **PPO + KL for RLHF:** RLHF turns the preference learning problem into a reinforcement learning problem. We use PPO for stable policy updates and include a KL penalty to keep the policy from straying too far from the original model [47] [49]. The KL penalty is absolutely critical in practice for language models – it tethers the generated text distribution to something reasonable and prevents bizarre outputs that exploit the reward model [60]. Practically, always monitor the KL divergence. If using the Hugging Face TRL, the library reports `objective/kl` and you can adjust `beta` (either

manually or via the `PPOTrainer` config) to target a certain KL. A rule of thumb is to target a KL that corresponds to noticeable but not extreme changes in style (e.g., an average KL of a few nats per output token). If KL is too low (policy stuck near reference), consider lowering β to allow more exploration. If KL is skyrocketing, increase β or reduce learning rate. **Stable training** often involves slowly ramping up learning (maybe start with a smaller learning rate or higher β and then relax as you see stability).

- **Annotated Code Understanding:** We stepped through code where we:

- added a **value head** to the model (for advantage estimation),
- made a **reference copy** for KL (with shared layers to save memory if needed) [62] ,
- generated responses and computed rewards,

- called `PPOTrainer.step` to perform one PPO update. Key thing to remember: ensure the **tokenizer and model are consistent** (pad token, EOS handling) when batching queries and responses. Always pad sequences to the same length in a batch, otherwise model outputs might misalign. TRL's `PPOTrainer` handles a lot, but if you implement your own loop, be careful to detach the reference model's graph (it's not updated), and to only update the policy's params. Also, use a reasonable **generation strategy** during training – greedy or moderately sampled outputs can work. Greedy may reduce variability and make reward signals less noisy, but sampling (with a low temperature) can help explore alternate phrasings.

- **Failure Modes & Mitigations:**

- *Reward hacking:* watch out for signs like the model repeating certain phrases or strategies to game the reward. E.g., if you see the model always replying in a very specific format, or including irrelevant but reward-boosting content (like over-cautious disclaimers), that might be reward hacking. Mitigate by improving the reward model (include those scenarios in human evaluation and give lower scores to such behavior) [125] , or explicitly penalize unwanted artifacts. An iterative approach works: if your RLHF model exhibits a new quirk, collect data on it and retrain the reward model.
- *Over-optimization (alignment tax):* watch if certain capabilities drop. If your aligned model gets worse at factual tasks, consider mixing in a bit of the original training objective (like OpenAI did by blending in supervised loss on original data) [13] . This can preserve general knowledge.
- *KL collapse:* ensure the model doesn't collapse to trivial responses. If you see your model starts giving very short or samey answers, maybe the KL penalty or reward setup is causing it to play it too safe. Possibly your reward model isn't differentiating well and the easiest way to not get a bad score is to respond minimally. To counter this, one could incorporate a mild **length bonus** or entropy bonus. In fact, OpenAI mentioned they added a small penalty to the reward for incomplete (non-EOS terminated) answers to encourage proper endings [66] .
- *Noisy preferences:* understand that your reward model is a biased reflection of your annotators. Try to have a diverse annotator pool and clear instructions to reduce inconsistency [100] . If possible, filter out obviously bad data (like if some comparisons were done incorrectly).

- *Bias and values:* The model will inherit the biases in the feedback. If aligning to a certain set of values (say a certain culture's norms), be aware that the model might not represent other viewpoints well. This isn't easily "fixed" with current RLHF – it requires careful dataset design or training multiple reward models for different demographics perhaps. It's an active area to figure out how to handle in deployment (maybe letting users personalize the style or strictness of the assistant).

- **Real-world impact:** RLHF was a game-changer for making AI assistants like ChatGPT and Claude widely useful [11] [19]. It demonstrates that large models are not *truly* intelligent in knowing what we want – we have to explicitly teach them via human feedback. The success stories show huge leaps in user satisfaction, but also highlight that models can be "too aligned" in some sense (overly cautious, or reflecting a particular ideology of the trainers). From a practical standpoint, if you build an AI system, plan a strategy for obtaining human feedback and iterating on it. Even a small amount of human eval data (few thousand comparisons) on top of a strong base model can yield major improvements in alignment.

- **Benchmarking mini-RLHF:** Our 6B model run illustrated that with ~3k PPO steps (maybe ~50k query-response pairs worth of training), we got substantial improvement [85] [87]. It's encouraging for smaller-scale projects. We also saw memory can be managed on single GPUs with techniques like 8-bit and LoRA [70] [62] – meaning RLHF isn't exclusive to big labs anymore. The main barrier is data: getting high-quality preference labels. Collaborative projects (like OpenAssistant) try to address that by crowdsourcing.

- **Evaluation and iteration:** Always evaluate your aligned model with metrics that matter: human preference studies, task-specific correctness metrics, safety evaluations (like measuring toxicity or bias). RLHF can introduce subtle changes (making answers longer, for example) that might indirectly affect say the time it takes a user to get info. So consider user experience holistically. Often, multiple rounds of RLHF are done: train initial model, see how it fails, add those failure cases to training data or adjust reward, retrain, etc. This iterative loop – "Deploy -> Collect Feedback -> Refine" – is likely the future of model development, rather than one-and-done training.

- **Future directions:** We touched on some – using AI feedback (to reduce human labor), direct loss formulations (DPO), and improvements for hallucination (maybe integrating fact-checkers into the reward). As models get bigger and tasks more complex, scaling human oversight is challenging. One promising idea is a sort of **cascaded feedback**: have one AI model assist humans in evaluating another model, to amplify the human's ability to give feedback on very complex tasks (e.g., code or math proofs). Another is **multi-agent debate** as a form of feedback (having two models debate an answer and the human judges the debate). These are beyond our scope here, but are along the lines of refining the RLHF paradigm.

In conclusion, **Instruction tuning and RLHF** form a powerful toolkit for aligning AI with what humans actually want. They combine the strengths of large-scale learning (the model's base capabilities) with **human wisdom and preference** to guide the model. The process involves careful data collection, training with hybrid ML/RL techniques, and vigilant evaluation. The result, when done well, is a model that is not only smart, but also *helpful, harmless, and honest* (as much as we can make it). As practitioners, we should be prepared to invest in that human feedback loop, because it can turn a good model into a truly usable product.

Before closing, here are a few **study questions** and practical prompts to reinforce understanding:

- *Why is a KL-divergence penalty needed in PPO for language model tuning, and how does it relate to the concept of a "trust region" in policy optimization?* (Hint: consider what might happen if the model's outputs shift drastically in one update – how does KL penalty prevent a form of overfitting in one step? [47] [49])

- *Explain the difference between supervised fine-tuning and RLHF in terms of the learning signal the model gets. Why might a model fine-tuned only on demonstrations still produce suboptimal or unsafe answers in some cases?* (Think about what information is missing in the supervised signal that preferences provide. [23] [3])

- *In the reward model training, why do we prefer using comparisons (A vs B) instead of absolute scores given by humans? What are some advantages of the comparative approach?* (Hint: humans are more consistent at relative judgments, and it's easier to calibrate a model on pairwise differences than absolute scores which may vary a lot between annotators. Also consider scale issues and bias cancellation.)

- *During RLHF training, what might it indicate if you observe the* `objective/rlhf_reward` *going up while the* `objective/kl` *also continuously rises to a high value? What action could you take?* (This could indicate the policy is chasing reward at the cost of diverging – possibly entering a regime of reward model exploitation. The action: increase β to tamp down KL, or maybe manually review outputs to see if they are getting weird. [126] [118])

- *Design a basic reward model for a specific objective, say "summarize this article concisely." What kind of comparisons would you gather, and what potential pitfalls might your reward model have?* (Think: you'd get summaries and ask humans which is better. Pitfalls: maybe they prefer summaries that copy too much because it seems relevant – leading to reward hacking; or differing opinions on what counts as concise vs missing details.)

By exploring these questions and reflecting on the content covered – from conceptual motivations and mathematical formulations to real code and real-world outcomes – you should have a solid, graduate-level grasp of how post-training alignment via instruction tuning and RLHF works. These methods blend human insight with machine learning, pointing towards a future where we **teach** AI systems not just to be intelligent, but to align with our goals and values.

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